

Panther Bob Study Guide

NC Middle School Battle of the Books · 2026–2027

16 books, key facts to know for every title

1. Agent Most Wanted	<i>Sonia Purnell</i>
2. All Thirteen	<i>Christina Soontornvat</i>
3. Blood in the Water	<i>Tiffany D. Jackson</i>
4. The Fire, the Water, and Maudie McGinn	<i>Sally J. Pla</i>
5. Island of Spies	<i>Sheila Turnage</i>
6. The Last Cuentista	<i>Donna Barba Higuera</i>
7. Long Lost	<i>Jacqueline West</i>
8. Marcus Vega Doesn't Speak Spanish	<i>Pablo Cartaya</i>
9. Nyxia	<i>Scott Reintgen</i>
10. Other Words for Home	<i>Jasmine Warga</i>
11. Restart	<i>Gordon Korman</i>
12. The Secret Battle of Evan Pao	<i>Wendy Wan-Long Shang</i>
13. Shark Teeth	<i>Sherri Winston</i>
14. Tristan Strong Punches a Hole in the Sky	<i>Kwame Mbalia</i>
15. Two Tribes	<i>Emily Bowen Cohen</i>
16. When We Flew Away	<i>Alice Hoffman</i>

Facts below are drawn from the same clue bank used in the site's games — arranged easiest to most obscure for each book.

1. Agent Most Wanted

by Sonia Purnell

- This real-life American spy was deemed "the most dangerous of all Allied spies" by the Gestapo during World War II.
 - This spy hiked over the Pyrenees Mountains into Spain to escape capture, despite having a prosthetic leg.
 - Before turning to espionage, this book's subject pursued a diplomatic career but was blocked because the State Department resisted appointing female diplomats.
 - This book is the young-readers adaptation of an adult biography originally titled "A Woman of No Importance."
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2. All Thirteen

by Christina Soontornvat

- This nonfiction account follows twelve boys and their coach from the Wild Boars soccer team, trapped underground for seventeen days.
 - This nonfiction book follows a youth soccer team called the Wild Boars, trapped by floodwaters in a cave in Thailand.
 - This author was actually visiting family in northern Thailand when the real-life rescue at the heart of her book took place.
 - The rescue operation in this book eventually involves thousands of volunteers and rescuers from around the globe over seventeen days.
 - This book braids the science of cave diving together with details of regional Buddhist culture and politics.
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3. Blood in the Water

by Tiffany D. Jackson

- This girl spends the summer on Martha's Vineyard with family friends while her father serves a prison sentence for a crime she believes he didn't commit.
 - A shark attack is first blamed for a death on this book's beach setting, but it soon becomes clear that isn't the real cause.
 - A teenage boy's mysterious death rocks the historic Black community of Oak Bluffs, and this book's narrator sets out to solve it.
 - This book's narrator calls her incarcerated father through a prison Inmate Calling Service at the very start of the story.
 - This was its bestselling YA author's first venture into middle grade fiction.
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4. The Fire, the Water, and Maudie McGinn

by Sally J. Pla

- A wildfire forces a girl and her dad to evacuate their mountain cabin, landing them in the beach town where he grew up.
 - This autistic main character is keeping a secret from her father about her stepfather's anger back home, all while learning to surf.
 - This book's author is a neurodivergent advocate who runs an online resource for neurodiversity in children's literature called "A Novel Mind."
 - This novel won the 2024 Schneider Family Book Award for its portrayal of an autistic girl finding acceptance among a community of surfers.
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5. Island of Spies

by Sheila Turnage

- German U-boats bombing ships off a North Carolina island turn a kids' detective game into a real WWII spy hunt.
 - Stick, Rain, and Neb call their homemade detective agency "the Dime Novel Kids" while hunting for a Nazi spy on this North Carolina island.
 - Ten-year-old Rain, one of the Dime Novel Kids, faces prejudice from some islanders because of her skin color and mysterious parentage.
 - This book's author grew up in North Carolina and researched real wartime history along the state's coast to write it.
 - Real German U-boats bombing cargo ships off the North Carolina coast are a key historical thread in this WWII middle-grade mystery.
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6. The Last Cuentista

by Donna Barba Higuera

- A grandmother tells her granddaughter a folktale about Fire Snake, a being born of the sun and the earth.
 - After Earth is destroyed by a collision with Halley's Comet, this twelve-year-old girl travels centuries into the future toward a planet called Sagan.
 - This book weaves references to the ancient epic of Gilgamesh into its story about preserving humanity's stories after Earth's destruction.
 - This girl's grandmother is a "cuentista," a traditional Mexican storyteller, and gives her a sun-shaped pendant before their final goodbye.
 - When this book's heroine wakes from centuries of suspended animation, an extremist faction called "the Collective" has taken over her spaceship.
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7. Long Lost

by Jacqueline West

- A girl discovers a mysterious library book called "The Lost One" soon after her family moves to a new Massachusetts town.
 - A supernatural figure called the Searcher is blamed for children vanishing in the woods near this book's small-town setting.
 - The library book at the center of this ghost story turns out to be the true account of an unsolved, century-old disappearance involving two sisters, Hazel and Pearl.
 - The town library at the heart of this mystery was once the mansion of a wealthy, long-dead heiress named Margaret Chisholm.
 - The mysterious book at the center of this ghost story keeps disappearing from its reader's possession, only to reappear at the library.
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8. Marcus Vega Doesn't Speak Spanish

by Pablo Cartaya

- Nicknamed the "Springfield Skyscraper" for his size, this boy travels to Puerto Rico hoping to find the father who left ten years earlier.
 - This boy walks a younger client named Danny to school each morning, though Danny is the one who actually speaks fluent Spanish.
 - Marcus's search for his father leads him to Uncle Ermenio's house and a much bigger extended family than he ever knew existed.
 - This book's title character is known only by nicknames tied to his size, like the "Mastodon of Montgomery Middle."
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9. Nyxia

by Scott Reintgen

- This boy leaves Detroit — and Earth — after being recruited by the powerful Babel Corporation.
 - Ten teen recruits compete to earn a trip to the hidden planet Eden, where a rare and valuable substance can be mined.
 - This boy is stabbed during a training exercise after a real blade is secretly swapped in for a fake one.
 - The humanoid beings native to the planet Eden, called Adamites, are hostile toward the human miners sent by Babel.
 - Given the chance to kill the doctor who betrayed him under a rule called "Primal Law," this book's hero chooses to let him go instead.
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10. Other Words for Home

by Jasmine Warga

- Twelve-year-old Jude must flee her home in Syria with her pregnant mother and move to Cincinnati, Ohio to live with relatives.
 - This novel-in-verse follows a girl who loved American movies back home, only to discover a new and unwelcome label at her new school: "Middle Eastern."
 - This author, who also wrote "A Rover's Story" and "The Shape of Thunder," set part of this Newbery Honor novel-in-verse in a real Cincinnati neighborhood called Clifton.
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11. Restart

by Gordon Korman

- After falling off his roof, this boy wakes up with no memory of being his school's most notorious bully.
 - This boy joins the video club run by one of his former bullying victims and discovers he has a real talent behind the camera.
 - This boy eventually confesses to stealing a Medal of Honor belonging to a decorated veteran he'd befriended during community service.
 - This boy's amnesia turns out to be connected to a secret he was hiding under the shingles on the roof of his own house.
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12. The Secret Battle of Evan Pao

by Wendy Wan-Long Shang

- This boy's family moves from California to Haddington, Virginia, hoping to escape the fallout from his father's financial scandal.
 - This boy learns that Chinese Americans actually served in the Civil War, a discovery that helps him push back at a history-obsessed new school.
 - A rifle shot fired into this family's new home puts suspicion on the very bully who has been tormenting the main character.
 - This boy's Uncle Joe is the only person his family knows in their new Virginia town, where his teacher runs an annual Civil War celebration at school.
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13. Shark Teeth

by Sherri Winston

- This girl dreams of joining her school's baton-twirling dance team, despite worrying her mother's instability could get in the way.
 - This girl hides her panic attacks from her mother while trying to hold onto a sense of normal life through a school dance team.
 - This girl's younger brother Lamar has fetal alcohol syndrome, adding to her responsibilities as her family's caretaker.
 - This girl has been bullied for years over the appearance of her teeth before a school administrator finally steps in to help.
 - A new assistant principal who also coaches a baton-twirling dance team takes a special interest in this book's main character's home life.
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14. Tristan Strong Punches a Hole in the Sky

by Kwame Mbalia

- This boy accidentally rips open a portal to a magical world called the MidPass by punching a Bottle Tree.
 - A sticky, doll-like creature named Gum Baby steals a grieving boy's journal, setting off a chase into a world of African American folk heroes.
 - This book's hero blames himself for failing to save his best friend Eddie in a bus accident before the story even begins.
 - This book's hero must convince the trickster god Anansi to help seal a hole torn in the sky — but bargaining with Anansi always has a price.
 - Folk heroes John Henry and Brer Rabbit are already exhausted from battle when this book's hero stumbles into their world.
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15. Two Tribes

by Emily Bowen Cohen

- This girl secretly takes a bus to Oklahoma using her bat mitzvah money to reconnect with her Muscogee father.
 - At her Jewish day school, this girl bonds with her friend Chloe, who is Chinese American, over the complexity of a blended heritage.
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16. When We Flew Away

by Alice Hoffman

- Written in cooperation with a real historical museum in Amsterdam, this book imagines its subject's life in the years just before she began her famous diary.
 - This story follows its real historical subject alongside her older sister Margot as ordinary freedoms in Amsterdam disappear one restriction at a time.
 - Small, eerie signs — vanishing magpies, disappearing rabbits, moths at the window — mark the growing danger in this real historical girl's story.
 - This book marks its real historical subject's shrinking freedoms with section headers that each list "what we lost."
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